



THE REAL
DEPRESSION T_T

CHAPTER 2

THE STRANGEST COMPUTER SETUP

I stayed in my car for a few seconds, completely confused.

The man was still typing.

The police officer was still walking toward him.

And the traffic was still completely stuck.

I looked at the time.

12:24 AM.

“This is ridiculous.”

I opened my car door and stepped out.

Rain immediately hit my face.

I pulled my jacket over my head and walked toward the strange setup.

The closer I got, the more bizarre it became.

The man had built an entire little workstation in the middle of the road.

His name, I would later discover, was **Arjun**.

He looked like he had been sitting there for hours. His clothes were soaked around the edges, his hair was messy from the rain, and his eyes were completely fixed on the glowing CRT monitor.

He wasn't looking at the traffic.

He wasn't looking at the police.

He wasn't looking at the hundreds of people watching him.

He was looking at one thing.

His code.

I tried to get closer.

Arjun immediately turned around.

And tried to slap me, and said:

“Don't come any closer.”

I stopped.

“Why?”

**No answer

I stared at him.

“...Okay?”

He turned back toward the computer.

I tried to see what he was working on.

He noticed immediately and covered the screen with his arm.

“No.”

“What are you even doing?”

“Debugging.”

“In the middle of a road?”

“Yes.”

“That doesn't answer my question.”

He ignored me.

I looked around.

That's when I noticed the floor.

Arjun wasn't sitting directly on the road.

He had built a raised wooden platform underneath the entire workstation.

His chair, desk, computer, UPS and all his equipment were sitting on it.

The wooden floor was slightly above the wet road, keeping his setup away from the puddles.

It wasn't exactly comfortable.

It wasn't exactly safe.

But somehow, it looked like he had planned the entire thing.

Then I noticed something else.

A thick bundle of cables was running from the platform toward the roadside.

I followed the cables with my eyes.

They disappeared into the darkness.

I looked farther.

And there it was.

An old electrical transformer pole stood roughly twenty-five meters away.

The rain was pouring around it.

Every few seconds, a tiny spark flashed near the equipment.

CRACK.

Everyone nearby jumped.

Arjun didn't even look up.

I pointed toward it.

"Is your computer connected to THAT?"

Arjun continued typing.

"Technically."

"Technically?!"

He finally looked at me.

"It's complicated."

"That is not an answer!"

Before I could say anything else, the police officer reached the platform.

He looked at Arjun.

Then the computer.

Then the cables.

Then the transformer.

Then the traffic jam.

He took a long breath.

“Sir.”

Arjun kept typing.

“Sir.”

Nothing.

“**SIR.**”

Arjun finally looked up.

“Yes?”

“You are sitting in the middle of a major road.”

“I know.”

“You have created a traffic jam.”

“I know.”

“You have cables running toward an electrical transformer.”

“I know.”

“You are operating a computer in the rain.”

“I know.”

The officer stared at him.

“And you have installed RGB lighting.”

Arjun looked at the glowing lights around his old computer.

There was a pause.

“...Yes.”

The officer rubbed his forehead.

“Why?”

Arjun looked genuinely confused.

“I like RGB.”

Behind us, someone shouted:

“BRO, WHO IS THE RGB FOR?”

Another person yelled:

“THE CARS CAN'T EVEN MOVE AND THIS GUY IS RUNNING GAMING MODE!”

A few people laughed.

The RGB continued glowing.

Red.

Blue.

Green.

Completely unnecessary.

Completely irritating.

And somehow impossible to ignore.

One driver leaned out of his window and shouted:

“LOOK AT THE SIGN!”

Everyone looked.

Someone had apparently placed a ridiculous homemade sign beside the platform.

It read:

GO HOME — OPTIONAL

The traffic erupted in laughter.

Another driver shouted:

“NEW UPDATE: ROAD CLOSED, BUT JAVA IS OPEN!”

Someone else yelled:

“BRO BUILT A DATA CENTER BEFORE BUILDING A HOUSE!”

Even the police officer looked like he was struggling not to laugh.

Arjun ignored everyone.

He typed another line.

Click.

Click.

Click.

I stepped closer again.

“What happens if someone looks at your screen?”

Arjun immediately pulled the monitor slightly toward himself.

“No one sees my code.”

“Why?”

“Because it's private.”

“It's literally in public.”

“Still private.”

The officer pointed at the monitor.

“Sir, I am going to need to see what you're doing.”

Arjun shook his head.

“No.”

The officer stared at him.

“Excuse me?”

“No one gets to see the code.”

For some reason, the entire crowd became quiet.

The rain became louder.

The transformer sparked again in the distance.

CRACK.

The CRT monitor flickered.

Arjun quickly placed one hand on the side of the screen.

For a moment, I caught a glimpse of something written in bright green text.

Numbers.

Code.

And one enormous error message.

Before I could read it, Arjun turned the monitor away.

I couldn't see anything else.

I looked at him.

He looked back at me.

Then he calmly returned to typing.

Click.

Click.

Click.

As if none of this was unusual.

As if the police officer wasn't standing beside him.

As if hundreds of cars weren't trapped behind him.

As if there wasn't a transformer sparking twenty-five meters away.

As if the entire road wasn't slowly turning into a bizarre computer laboratory.

And then I noticed one final detail.

There was another sign underneath the first one.

It said:

DEBUGGING IN PROGRESS

PLEASE DO NOT DISTURB

ESTIMATED COMPLETION: UNKNOWN

I stared at it.

Then at Arjun.

Then at the enormous traffic jam.

I suddenly had the feeling that I wasn't going home anytime soon.

And I still had no idea what was actually happening on that computer



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